

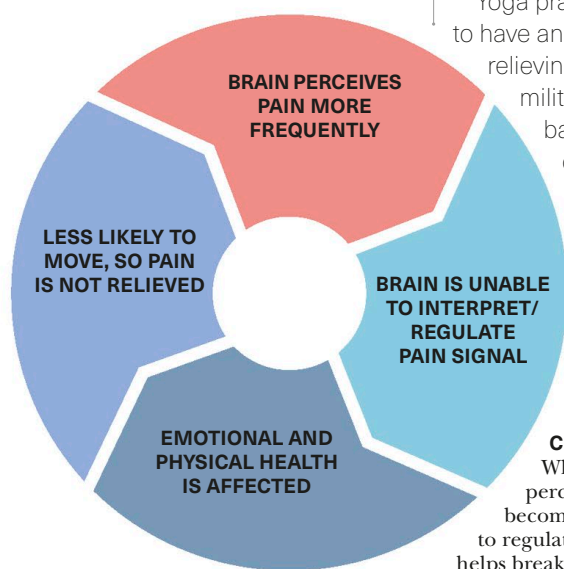
CHRONIC PAIN

Acute pain, such as an ankle sprain or a slip-and-fall injury, often needs rest to heal, which may mean avoiding or modifying yoga poses. But when pain becomes chronic, mind-body practices such as yoga have been shown to be well-suited to providing a safe supplement to medical care.

Q CAN YOGA REALLY HELP WHEN PAIN BECOMES CHRONIC?

Yes, there is evidence to show that it can help. Pain becomes chronic when it persists beyond the healing time of about three months. If you suffer from chronic pain, such as many cases of back pain or arthritis, you generally don't need to rest more because there may be little to no physical damage to heal. In fact, you probably need to move more because exercise tends to help relieve chronic pain, along with reducing associated stress.

Yoga practices have been shown to have an analgesic—or pain-relieving—effect. In one study of military veterans with lower back pain, opioid use declined in all subjects after a 12-week, twice weekly yoga program.



CHRONIC PAIN CYCLE

When the brain frequently perceives signals as pain, it becomes injured and is unable to regulate its response. Yoga helps break the cycle.

MYTH-BUSTER

Meditation relieves pain because of the placebo effect.

Recent research has shown that mindfulness meditation works better than a placebo in reducing pain. Subjects were exposed to a painful heat stimulus before and after receiving treatment: a placebo cream, “fake meditation,” and traditional mindfulness meditation. The intensity and unpleasantness of the pain was evaluated psychophysically and by functional neuroimager. The mindfulness group’s pain intensity and unpleasantness reduced most significantly.

Four **20**-minute mindfulness classes can reduce pain’s unpleasantness by **57%**